Where should the next InPost lockers go?

Locker coverage in Tower Hamlets | An independent analysis using public data

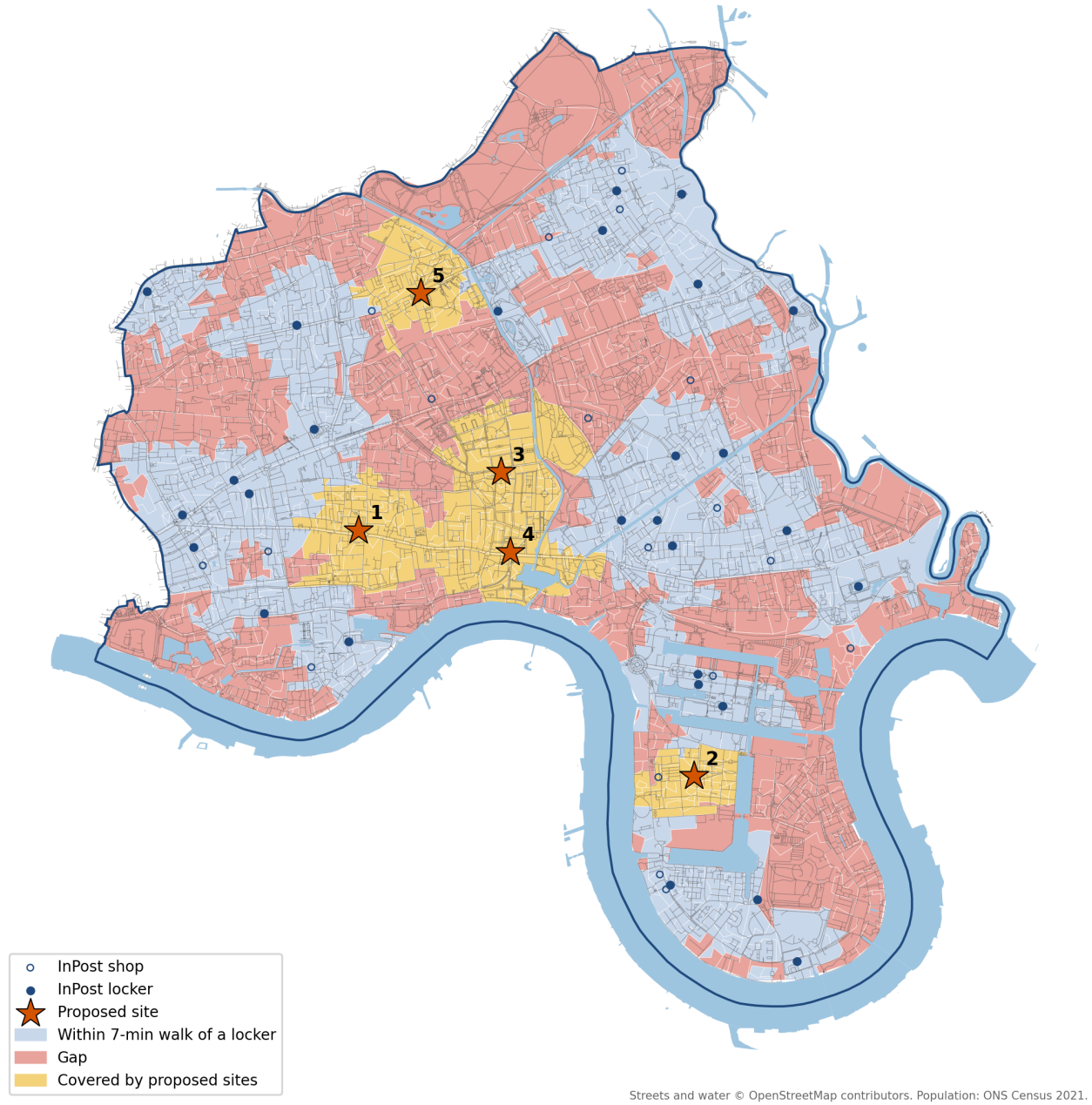
Why Tower Hamlets? It is one of London's densest boroughs, and its canals, docks and railways make many short distances long walks, so exactly where a locker sits makes a real difference to who can reach it.

40.6%
of residents live within a 7-minute walk of an InPost locker

57.4%
within 7 minutes of any InPost point, including shops

+52,000
residents reached by five new lockers, taking locker coverage to 57.4%

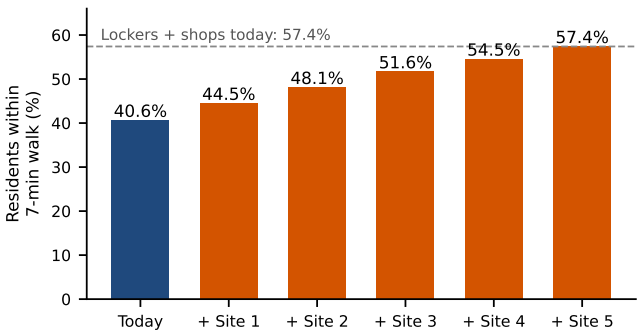
InPost locker coverage, Tower Hamlets



Coverage by Census 2021 Output Area (913 areas, 310,303 residents). Walking distances follow the street and path network, so the Regent's Canal, docks, railways and the A12 are treated as the barriers they are. Lockers just outside the borough are counted towards coverage but not drawn.

Five sites that add the most coverage

#	Site	Type	Residents
1	Nowrin Stores	Convenience	12,005
2	Co-op Food, Cassilis Road	Supermarket	11,191
3	Ahmed's Convenience Store	Convenience	11,031
4	Limehouse	Station	8,952
5	FreshGo	Convenience	8,873
	Total		**52,052**



Sites were chosen greedily: at each step, the candidate that brings the most *currently uncovered* residents within a 7-minute walk is added, so no two sites compete for the same people. Candidates were the borough's 359 supermarkets, convenience stores, fuel stations and rail stations, the kinds of host InPost already partners with.

So what

- **Five lockers would match what 22 shops add today, but around the clock.** Five well-placed lockers lift locker coverage from 40.6% to 57.4%, the level today's lockers reach only with the help of 22 shop points, which keep shop hours.
- **The biggest gap is a central belt, not the edges.** Sites 1, 3 and 4 sit next to each other between the existing clusters in the west and east of the borough, and together reach about 32,000 residents.
- **One residual gap to look at next:** the east side of the Isle of Dogs stays uncovered even after site 2, because the docks lengthen walks there. A sixth site would need checking on the ground.

Method

- **Lockers:** 56 InPost points (34 lockers, 22 shops) collected by hand from InPost's own locker finder in October 2026, including points just over the borough boundary, and geocoded by postcode.
- **People:** Census 2021 usual residents for 913 Output Areas (ONS via Nomis), each placed at a point inside its area.
- **Walking distance:** shortest path on the OpenStreetMap walking network; 7 minutes at 4.8 km/h, about 560 m. Straight-line coverage (500 m) is 63.7%, a reminder of how much barriers matter here.
- **Tools:** Python (GeoPandas, OSMnx, NetworkX, Matplotlib). Code and data are in the linked repository.

Data quality and limitations

- **Open data was not good enough.** OpenStreetMap listed only 16 InPost lockers in and around the borough and matched just 24% of the real ones, so the dataset was rebuilt from InPost's own finder rather than reporting a misleading 13% coverage figure.
- **Approximate locations.** Lockers are placed at their postcode's centre (typically within about 100 m). One locker (13–15 Dod Street) has a postcode the geocoder did not recognise and was left out; a second locker on the same street covers the area.
- **Residents are not demand.** The model weights everyone equally; parcel volumes, footfall and commuters (notably around Canary Wharf) would change the ranking.
- **Not a site survey.** Candidate shops come from OpenStreetMap; space, landlord interest and existing competitor lockers were not assessed.
- **Not comparable to InPost's 75% headline.** InPost's figure covers all out-of-home points across London, Birmingham and Manchester; this is one borough, measured along real walking routes.

Independent analysis using public data; not affiliated with or endorsed by InPost. Street and candidate data © OpenStreetMap contributors (ODbL). Population: ONS Census 2021, Open Government Licence.